

R' Chaim Kanievsky's sefer on chumash by Rabbi Shai Graucher quotes the pasuk from **פרשת בהר** (25:21): **וְצִוִּיתִי אֶת בְּרַכְתִּי לָכֶם בְּשָׁנָה הַשְּׁשִׁית וְעָשִׂיתָ אֶת הַתְּבוּאָה לְשָׁלֹשׁ הַשָּׁנִים**. R' Chaim quotes the **איש חזון** in **מסכת** that this **ברכה** is still in effect in our times, and some people have the **zechus** to see it. He brings down a **מעשה** which happened in the famous **מושב** of **קוממיות**. At the time the story was written, it had happened 60 years earlier, today it's about 75 years ago. I wanted to share this story for two reasons. Number one: **משיח** is coming, and it behooves us to spend some time learning about the **בארץ** **מצוות התלויות**. Number two: the **Brisker Rav**, upon hearing this **מעשה**, said it's a **mitzvah** to publicize and repeat the story. So if you didn't hear it yet, although I'm sure most of you have, I'm fulfilling the **צוואה** of the **Brisker Rav**, which is a tremendous **זכות**.

The **שמיטה** year was 5719, and at that time, very few people were keeping the **mitzvah** of **שמיטה**. However, **קוממיות** was a place dedicated exclusively to people who kept **שמיטה**. Those of us not involved in agriculture cannot really fathom the depths of commitment required to keep the **mitzvah** of **שמיטה**. Imagine taking off an entire year - how will you support your family? What will you return to after the year is over? The farmers of **קוממיות** did not look for any **היתרים**, they did not hold of **מכירה**, and they did only that which was required to preserve the land as the **תורה** permits. The rest of the time they went to **kollel**, sat down in the **בית מדרש** and learned, which is exactly what the **sefarim** say **שמיטה** is all about. To feed their livestock, the farmers would plant special crops called fodder in the summer of the sixth year, so that the majority of the growth would occur before **שמיטה**. That way, they could harvest and use it during **שמיטה** in accordance with the **הלכות**, ensuring their animals had food.

That year, 5719, a tremendous plague of **ארבה** hit the Middle East. The only place it didn't hit, as we know the famous **רמב"ן**, **מצרים** was never hit. But **ארץ ישראל** is affected by **ארבה**. Hashem never promised that locusts wouldn't come to **ארץ ישראל**. Swarms were devastating fields and orchards throughout the land. The people of **קוממיות** began to worry: if the plague reached their fields, they wouldn't be able to feed their animals. They couldn't plant anything after the locusts left, because it was **שמיטה**. As **Shabbos** was coming closer and closer, R' Medelson, the **rav** of **קוממיות** said, "Don't worry, Hashem will save us because we observe this **mitzvah**."

As the sun set and **Shabbos** began, everyone could hear the loud, eerie sound of the insects devouring everything in their path. A dark cloud of **ארבה** was coming from the southwest, and the nearby settlement of **זבדיאל** was being destroyed. However, before the astonished eyes of all the people of **קוממיות**, they saw a **נס** in our own time, just 75 years ago. The locusts were literally jumping around the borders of **קוממיות**, like a **קריעת ים סוף**. Everything around the **מושב** was hit, but **קוממיות** remained completely untouched, not a single blade of grass was eaten. R' Mendelson said, "The **רידב"ז** said in 5649 that when people did not keep **שמיטה**, a plague of locusts came and destroyed everything as a punishment from Hashem. But we kept **שמיטה**, and Hashem protected us. He showed us His **חן**, and now we must sing **זמירות** and thank Him." R' Medelson traveled to **ירושלים** to relate to the **Brisker Rav** what had happened. The **Brisker Rav** quoted to him the **רמב"ן** which I mentioned, that ever since Hashem said that **ארבה** would not come to **מצרים**, it has never been there. And the fact that the plague bypassed their **מושב** is **ממש** a **נס** and must be publicized, as the pasuk in **Tehillim** (105:2) says: **שִׁיחוּ בְּכָל נֶפֶלְאוֹתָיו**.

Every single media outlet in **ארץ ישראל** was notified of this **מעשה**, and they all came to see it. People saw this, and who knows whether or not that stimulated the growth of **שמיטה**. The bottom line of the story is we should be learning these **הלכות**, we should know what is allowed, what is not allowed. The **הלכות** are there, it's all in the **גמרא** and **שולחן ערוך**. **B'eizras Hashem**, may we have the **זכות** to be able to merit fulfilling these **מצוות** very quickly when **משיח** will come **אמן** **בימינו**.

